

urmare a acțiunilor regimurile profasciste ale ustașilor, Croația, respectiv ale „crucilor cu săgeți”, Ungaria, acesta din urmă în regiunile croate anexate de Ungaria, Wachsmuth realizează pe baza unei cercetări de teren radiografia câtorva destine individuale ale băieșilor prinși între croați și sârbi în timpul războiului civil din fosta Iugoslavie de după 1990. Capitolele lui Măran și Salo au o tentă mai puțin traumatică, abordând strategiile de adaptare și integrare ale băieșilor în Banatul sârbesc, respectiv SUA. Sosiți ca ursari în circurile din Austro-Ungaria începând cu anii 1880, băiașii/*Ludar* își schimbă de-a lungul generațiilor aria de locuire, ocupațiile și stilurile de viață, ajungând să fie asimilați în prezent în societatea americană. În Banatul sârbesc în schimb, identitatea băiașilor persistă, ea preluând identitatea românilor asimilați, precum arată Măran în cazul a două localități rurale, Novo Selo și Sefkerin. Ultimul capitol cade în afara abordărilor din restul volumului, fiind o analiză a ADN-ului populației de băieși din două localități croate.

Volumul editat de Sorescu-Marinković, Kahl și Sikimić se adaugă unei serii consistente coagulată în ultimele două decenii care pune tematica băieșilor într-un cadru de cercetare academic și coerent. Îi lipsește un cadru teoretic unitar, deși unele capitole încearcă să depășească abordarea strict descriptivă. Domeniul este însă încă în stadiul de acumulare a datelor și tipurilor de cazuri, în această direcție volumul aducând contribuții notabile, precum cazurile comunităților de băiași din Grecia, Ucraina sau SUA.

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Constantin Eretescu, *Moartea lui Patroclu: studii și articole de etnologie*, București, Spandugino, 2020, ISBN 978-606-8944-47-0, 375 p. [The Death of Patroclus: ethnological studies and articles].

One of the most popular contemporary Romanian ethnologist today, Constantin Eretescu has reissued his collection of articles, studies and book reviews that first appeared together in 2015 under the title *Moartea lui Patroclu* [The Death of Patroclus]. Not to be confused with a monograph starting from the doom of the hero of *The Iliad*, the volume actually examines traditional culture and society in general, highlighting parallels between varied and sometimes distant cultural spaces, among which the subject of Romanian ethnology holds a special place (in this particular book).

The first part of the volume, *Studies*, consists of no more than 10 ethnological essays, most of them enriched by comparative approaches, concerning varied themes of the global and national heritage. The study that opens the book is *The Death of Patroclus. Moments of an ancient funerary ceremonial*, in which the author, starting with the data given in Canto XXIII of *The Iliad*, seeks to demonstrate that the funerary rituals described by Homer are in fact ethnologically accurate. Eretescu dismantles each one of Ian Rutherford's three main arguments that previously deemed the funerary ceremony of Patroclus (as

they appear in Homer) as aberrant from a scientific perspective. While also offering a brief history of the study of the ancient Greek rituals that revolve around death, the Romanian ethnologist finds that the description present in *The Iliad* faithfully illustrates the procedure in which the funerals were held for heroes fallen in battle far from home in the geometric period. Moreover, the study reveals how some of the practices found in the epic have survived in interesting ways until modern times in the Balkan world, and that includes the Romanian territory (one such practice is the hair offering).

However, one of the shortcomings of this volume in general is that Eretescu dwells on such interesting connections rather briefly, making these appear gratuitous. This is unfortunate given that a synthetic comparative scope is what the author excels in achieving otherwise: many of the links he highlights between cultures most heterogeneous are unprecedented. Such is the case of *The Wake in Ireland*, the author's "reading notes" on some prestigious works concerning the Irish funerary rites (Lady Wilde, Patrick Kennedy, Henry Morris, John. G.A. Prim etc.). "The forms of the wake in Ireland present some surprising similarities with the Romanian custom of the wake as it appears in the areas of Vrancea, Hunedoara, subcarpathian Russia, but also other areas of the world."¹(40). Death and the various rites surrounding it seem to constitute the common trope of the first and broadest part of the book, a fact that could be seen as divulging the volume's overarching concern, i.e. the endangered status of traditional rites in the contemporary world. Aside from the previously mentioned papers, *thanatos* is present in intriguing studies such as: *The white mourning. The colours of mourning; Journey towards the realm of eternal youth; The cross and the Christian symbols in the customs of the Romanians* and even *The myth of the honest thief. Robin Hood and his descendants*.

The second part of the book is dedicated to **People**. In this section, Constantin Eretescu recognizes the efforts, reconstructs the profiles and pays his respects to five hardworking anthropologists: John V. Murra, an important researcher of the Inca culture; the ethnomusicologist Gottfried Habenicht; Ovidiu Bîrlea one of the most important Romanian ethnologists of the last century; Ana Radu Chelariu a folklorist of Romanian extraction now working in the United States and Sabina Cornelia Stroescu, the indisputable specialist of the Romanian folkloric anecdote (*snoava*). They all have in common the fact that some, if not all, of their scientific work took place in or can be traced back to the Romanian territory, sometimes under truly unfavourable conditions. The homages paid in this volume to his specialty colleagues or predecessors reflect Eretescu's care for the individuals behind great scientific and most of the times even ethical contributions. The humane side of the scientist is an aspect to bear in mind, the author suggests, and these studies dedicated to people are Eretescu's duty (and ours as well) to save meritorious work and personalities from oblivion. Other such efforts of recuperation to be found in the volume beyond its second part are the studies dedicated to Al.Vasili-Tărătuși, Gh. Madan (two active but almost forgotten Moldavian folklorists of the beginning of the 20th century) and Mihail Vulpescu (an ethnomusicologist, folklorist, teacher, visual artist and opera singer mostly active during the first half of the previous century).

¹ „Formele pe care le ia petrecerea de priveghi în Irlanda prezintă asemănări surprinzătoare cu obiceiul priveghiului românesc așa cum îl cunoaștem din zona Vrancea, din Hunedoara, Rusia subcarpatică, dar și din alte zone ale lumii”. All Romanian language references have been translated by the author of the review.

Nonetheless, the man whose work is most cherished in the present volume, one might say the MVP of the volume (besides Eretescu himself) is Iordan Datcu. Out of the eleven books reviewed in the third chapter, seven bear the signature of the octogenarian ethnologist, who, in Constantin Eretescu's words is "without a doubt one of the most significant and contemporary researchers of the Romanian folkloric literature, and the most hardworking and skillful editor and curator of folklore ever produced by our culture"² (339–340). Another significant place in this third part entitled **Books**, is held by the people of the Jiu Valley (called *momârlani* in Romanian). The small community of these villagers and their traditions constitute the object of study of three books that are reviewed in this chapter. The books belong to Ioan Lascu and Dumitru Gălăţan-Jieţ, both researchers having an insider status in the respective community.

Moving on to the last part of the volume, called *In dialogue*, the reader is presented with two interviews: *What's in a Fairy Tale?* and *An ignored culture*. What is striking in these interviews is Eretescu's democratic and professional attitude, arguing for the scientific relevance of two rather ignored but very widespread folkloric products belonging, this time, to the urban world: the political joke and the urban legend.

I would like to add to this non-exhaustive review some other "*leitmotifs*" found in the volume that speak about the author's curiosities and nature. For instance, Eretescu never misses the chance to highlight and salute any form of resistance against ideological abuses. He admits he has perceived himself, at every age, as being in a tense relationship with authority. Another recurrent topic is migration and its repercussions, its history and the questions we must answer for ourselves in regards to these shifts in culture. It is also important to highlight the attention Constantin Eretescu pays to the evolution of Romanian ethnology (as a rigorous discipline) and some of its branches. Among them, the Romanian folk mythology appears to hold a special place. In one of the articles of the first chapter he reconfigures the history of this particular field of study. What's more, the author does not hesitate to present his complaints: "The lack of the book editor, of the job that takes responsibility for the quality of the publication is felt deeply in the publishing houses and the press of today"³(332). In all these regards he proves himself to be genuinely concerned about the state of Romanian study of folklore in general.

The back cover of the book highlights that Constantin Eretescu reconstructs a gallery of essential biographies for the field of study that he is in. One might say that the greatest merit of the book is the essential *bibliographies* that the author inevitably bestows upon the young researchers. Anyone familiar with Eretescu's writing style can testify for the clarity of his formulation and ideas in general. The same can be said about the scientific apparatus that he operates with, professionally chosen and reliable.

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² „Iordan Datcu, este, fără îndoială, unul dintre cei mai însemnați cercetători contemporani ai literaturii populare românești și cel mai harnic și priceput editor și redactor de folclor pe care l-a produs cultura noastră”.

³ „Lipsa redactorului de carte, a omului de meserie care răspunde de calitatea publicației se simte acut în editurile și în presa noastră de astăzi”.